



Department
for Work &
Pensions

Ms J Smith
21 The Street
Newcastle-upon-Tyne

Carers Allowance Unit
Mail Handling Site A
Wolverhampton
WV98 2AB

NE 11 1AA

www.gov.uk

Telephone: 0800 731 0297

Your reference:

**Important: Please read this letter carefully
and give us as much information as possible**

Dear Ms J Smith

It is important that you contact us about this letter no later than 12 July 2026. If we do not hear from you by this date, we will make our decision on the basis of the information we have now. **If you need more time to reply please let us know straight away.**

If you normally have someone who helps you with your claim you may wish to show them this letter.

We are looking at your **Carer's Allowance** award. It appears from the information we have that you failed to report a change of circumstances promptly, and we need more information about this from you.

You are required to provide information, with your claim or when asked, which is correct and complete. This includes correcting any mistakes and reporting any changes in your circumstances straight away. If you don't do this and this means that you have been overpaid benefit, then this could also lead to a **£50 Civil Penalty** being imposed.

We therefore need you to tell us if there was a reason why you failed to report a change in your circumstances promptly. You started

Overpayment of Carer's Allowance

Amount overpaid: £307

**Period of overpayment:
24 March 2026 to 21
April 2026**

Other ways to
communicate with us

If you need braille, British
Sign Language, a
hearing loop,
translations, large print,
Easy Read, audio or
something else, please
contact us.

If you use Relay UK dial
18001 followed by our
telephone number.

Please turn over

employment on 24 March 2026, which you only told us about on 21 April 2026.

We will consider whether to impose a Civil Penalty on the basis of the information you give us. It is therefore important that you tell us the reasons for your actions as soon as possible. If we do not hear from you by 12 July 2026, we will make our decision on the basis of the information we have now.

If a Civil Penalty is imposed, you will have to pay this in addition to repaying any overpayment.

We will write to you again telling you what we have decided.

What the law allows

Social Security law allows a Civil Penalty of **£50** to be imposed if it is decided that you were overpaid benefit because you:

- negligently made incorrect statements regarding your claim without taking reasonable steps to correct them or
- failed to provide information or evidence about the claim without reasonable excuse or
- failed to report changes in circumstances regarding the claim promptly without reasonable excuse

What to do now

Please contact us on 0800 731 0297 by 12 July 2026 to give us your contact details. We can then arrange to call you back so we can check the information we have is correct and if there is a reason why you failed to report the change in your circumstances promptly.

If you prefer to reply in writing, please complete the 'Your Reply' page below and return it in the envelope provided by 12 July 2026.

Yours sincerely,

Office manager

More information about Civil Penalties

Question: Is a Civil Penalty a criminal matter?

Answer: No. The Civil Penalty is intended for those who fail to take proper care of a benefit claim or award, resulting in an overpayment. It is not intended for those who deliberately undertake in fraudulent criminal behaviour.

Details on the Department's use of Civil Penalties can be found at www.gov.uk.

Question: If I have been overpaid benefit and need to pay the money back, will that mean that a Civil Penalty will automatically be imposed?

Answer: No. Each case will be considered individually.

There are many reasons why a person might make a mistake in giving information, may not have responded appropriately to a request for information or did not report a change in circumstances promptly. There may also be good reasons for the mistake or failure. The Department will look at all the circumstances which led to the overpayment in deciding whether or not a Civil Penalty is appropriate.

This is why it is important that you respond to this letter as soon as possible.

Question: If it is decided that I have not been overpaid benefit, could a Civil Penalty still apply?

Answer: No. There must always be an overpayment of benefit for a Civil Penalty to be considered and imposed.

Question: How will I be informed about the outcome of your decision?

Answer: By letter. If it is decided that a penalty is to be paid, we will write to you again. The letter will explain our decision and how much you will need to pay. The letter will also explain what to do if you disagree with our decision.

Your Reply

Please record below:

Your full name:

National Insurance Number:

Please reply to the enquiry above and return in the envelope provided.

The information DWP collects from and about you depends mainly on the reason for your business with us.

We will use this information about you for all of the Department's purposes, which include:

- social security benefits and allowances
- child support
- employment and training
- investigation of offences relating to social security and tax credits
- retirement planning, private pensions policy, pensions and war pensions

DWP uses information to deal with enquiries and complaints, to provide DWP services, to protect public funds and to conduct research and produce statistics to monitor and improve our services.

We will obtain information about you as the law allows from other organisations to check the information you give us, protect public funds and to improve our services.

DWP also shares information with other organisations as the law allows, for example to protect against crime, to help local authorities providing welfare services and with H M Revenue and Customs.

DWP uses external suppliers to help deliver some services. We also use technology to make decisions and improve our services. We will only ask you for information about your health when this is needed for a benefit or service you are using. We will keep your information secure and make sure nobody has access to it who should not.

Please look at the DWP Personal Information Charter on **www.gov.uk** to find out more about:

- your information rights
- how to request a copy of your information
- DWP's data controller details and other data protection information
- how long DWP will keep your data for
- more detail about how DWP uses personal information

Treating people fairly

We are committed to the Equality Act 2010 and treating people fairly. To find out more about this law, search 'Equality' on www.gov.uk

Call charges

Calls to 0800 numbers are free from personal mobiles and landlines.

Why DWP needs personal information and how we treat it

We treat personal information carefully. We may use it for any of our purposes. To learn more about information rights and how we use information, please see our DWP Personal Information Charter at www.gov.uk/dwp/personal-information-charter